



Concorde

This aircraft is the world's first and only supersonic airliner. Concorde was the product of the cream of British and French aeronautical engineering talent, its exquisite shape—which still looks out of this world, more than 50 years since it first flew—actually reflects pure functionality. Capable of cruising at twice the speed of sound, Concorde halved the typical transatlantic journey time and made air travel glamorous once more.

CONCORDE WAS THE RESULT of an Anglo-French agreement signed in 1962. Built in Toulouse, Aerospatiale prototype 001 was the first to fly, on March 2, 1969. The British Aircraft Corporation prototype, 002, took to the air from Filton Airfield, Gloucestershire, just over a month later, on April 9. Production started just as environmental concerns were growing and the oil crisis of the mid-1970s was developing, leading to US airlines

Pan American and TWA canceling their options to buy. In the end, only 16 aircraft were built, operating for most of their lives with BA and Air France. From the first scheduled service in 1976, there was not a single aircraft loss or passenger injury until the infamous crash of Air France Flight 4590, with the loss of all on board, in July 2000. Despite enjoying success in later years, Concorde was retired from commercial operations in 2003.

Restoration of a legend

Retired from test flying and trials work in 1981, Concorde G-BBDG languished for many years at Filton, serving as a source of spares for the operational fleet. Ending up as little more than a bare shell, it was transported by road to the Brooklands Museum at Weybridge, Surrey, where it has been painstakingly restored.

